Colossians 3:1–11 — Leader / Learner Guide

Looking Up, Putting Off · a one-page guide for leaders and learners

Christ Is All — A Study of Colossians · TheGospelVault.com · @iJohn.316 (Instagram)

① Big Idea and Context

Big idea: Since believers are raised with Christ and their life is hidden with Him, they must seek the things above and bring their practice up to their position, for Christ is all, and in all.

"Therefore" (3:1) turns the letter from doctrine to practice. Every command in chapters 3–4 rests on the believer's union with Christ taught in chapters 1–2.

- **Look up (3:1–4):** seek and set the mind on things above; life hidden; glory ahead.
- **Put to death and put aside (3:5–8):** sexual sin and greed; anger, malice, slander, foul talk.
- **Put away the lie (3:9–11):** the new self; no elite in Christ.

② Position and Practice — Three Anchor Verses

Verse	What it says	Teaching point
3:1	*"if you have been raised up with Christ, keep seeking the things above"*	First have the life, then live it; keep on seeking.
3:3–4	*"your life is hidden with Christ in God … you also will be revealed with Him in glory"*	Hidden now (secure), revealed later (glory and reward).
3:11	*"no distinction … but Christ is all, and in all"*	No one has more of Christ; how much of me does He have?

Ryrie: "All doctrine should be practical. All practice should be doctrinal."

"Members" (v.5): the acts our members commit, not literal body parts (cf. Matt. 5:29–30).

③ Teaching Flow

1. **The requirement (3:1a)** — Since raised with Christ; you can't live the life until you have it.
2. **Seek and set your mind (3:1b–2)** — Heart and mind fixed on Christ at the right hand.
3. **Hidden and revealed (3:3–4)** — Died, hidden, secure; revealed with Him in glory.
4. **Put off the old (3:5–8)** — Five sins of the body; five sins of the mouth.
5. **The new self (3:9–11)** — Renewed in knowledge and image; Christ is all.

④ Clarify While Teaching

- **"Put to death" vs. "consider as dead":** NKJV and NASB95 render *nekrōsate* differently; both mean decisively deal with these practices.
- **Wrath (3:6):** the study takes it as God's judgment on unbelievers ("sons of disobedience," a phrase some manuscripts omit), not a threat of hell to believers.
- **"Do not lie" (3:9):** most commentators take it as a general command; the study also applies it to the lie of spiritual superiority drawn from vv.10–11.
- **Avoid exact counts:** do not cite a precise number of commands in chs. 3–4 unless you have counted them in your own translation.

⑤ Discussion and Close

1. Where does your mind naturally go when it is not busy, toward things above or on earth?
2. Why must a person be "raised with Christ" before he can obey 3:1–2?
3. What does "Christ is all, and in all" mean for how we treat other believers?

Close: Next, the "put on" side: the believer's new wardrobe and code of conduct (3:12–17). "Christ is all, and in all."

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